China also adopted the relic culture associated with Buddhism, and various Chinese ruling dynasties sought to acquire items associated with Lord Buddha, including ashes and pieces of bone left in his funeral pyre. There were Chinese rulers who, having heard of the legend of King Ashoka constructing 84,000 stupas across India to house Buddhist relics, sought to do the same in their own kingdom. As we have seen in the previous chapter, the Tang diplomatic mission to King Harsha's court in the seventh century went on a pilgrimage to Bodh Gaya and carried back a rubbing of the footprint of the Buddha engraved on stone. Saplings from the Bodhi tree were carried to all over East and South-East Asia, to grow into sacred locations themselves.

But over time the origins of these ways of thinking and behaviour and the ritual practices – the use of Buddhist symbols and motifs – became progressively obscured in China. During the second millennium, the steady stream of cultural and religious influences from India became a trickle. As in the caves of Dunhuang, Buddhism began to be moulded into a distinctively Chinese phenomenon, its imported origins receding into the background. India was still regarded as the original home of Buddhism, but in the medieval age its image in China gradually dimmed into a vague and distant land, lying well beyond the known Chinese world. This was a gradual process, beginning in the eighth century but accelerating in the second millennium, after 1000 CE .

Then began a phase in which there emerged, over time, a 'Buddhism with Chinese characteristics'. From striving to create a replica of the sacred land in China and searching for the 'authentic' Indian version of the faith, we witness the creation and consolidation of an alternative Buddhist universe, with China at its centre, radiating the faith to countries on its periphery, in particular Korea, Japan and Vietnam. During this period, it is Chinese monks who performed the role which Indian monks had in the past, carrying the Buddha's message to adjacent realms. The widespread adoption of block printing, which originated in China during the Tang dynasty (618–906 CE), played an important role in the spread of Buddhism from China to East Asia and to Tibet. Well-known Chinese monasteries and